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Professor Hanna Bäck and the selection committee
Department of Political Science, Lund University

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Re: PhD student in Political Science, "A Divisive Spiral?" (PA2026/2879)

Dear Professor Bäck, dear members of the committee,

If a politician sounds more hostile on Facebook than in the Riksdag, either the politician has changed their tone or the instrument reading them has. *A Divisive Spiral?* asks whether politicians, voters and algorithms push each other towards affective polarisation, and it plans to recruit a PhD student with data science skills. That is the profile I bring. My own research so far has been about the instrument: whether a machine-labelled measure of opinion means the same thing on different platforms. I am applying because I want to add political science to that skill, and because your project's second question, whether engagement teaches representatives to be more hostile, is the one I most want to answer.

Qualifications and eligibility. I hold an MSc in Data Analytics from the University of Portsmouth (Distinction, 2025), which I studied as a Chevening Scholar. It comprises 90 second-cycle ECTS credits, including an independently written thesis of 30 ECTS, examined and graded at 78/100. The thesis studied public reaction to UK economic policy (taxation, welfare, inflation and stimulus) in 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, using a fine-tuned BERT model. It is a study of public opinion on government policy, and I ask the department to assess it as equivalent in relation to the project. Its weakness taught me most: the model was checked against labels seeded by a lexicon, and I had assumed that a "negative" post means the same on every platform. With my supervisor, Dr Ella Haig, I turned that into a methods paper, *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv:2610.16757), which treats each platform as a survey mode and applies measurement invariance and differential item functioning to machine-labelled opinion. Both are attached.

Experience on the project's merits. *Research related to the project's themes:* besides the thesis and paper, I was an analyst at M+C Saatchi Fluency in London on a twelve-month study of 100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions, and my work there feeds reports read by UK government communications teams. *Automated text analysis:* I fine-tune BERT, XLM-R and DeBERTa classifiers, and at Artemis AI, the social media start-up I co-founded and lead as CTO, I designed LLM labelling in which Claude labels posts and explains each label, rules mined from those explanations guide a second model, and the results are checked against posts our team labelled by hand. Much of that work concerns hostility: toxicity classifiers, a detector for sudden storms of hostile comments, and filters that stop dialect and banter being read as hostility. *Programming and large-scale data:* I work in Python and SQL daily; at Dubizzle Labs I led three engineers collecting text across 15 markets in English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi, and at Fluency I collect from ten platforms every day. *Languages:* I do not yet speak Swedish or Finnish. I have spent years checking text models in languages I do not read fluently, which is why my plan relies on native-speaker coding, and I would start Swedish courses in my first term.

What I would contribute. The group's recent work measures elite negativity with dictionaries and calls for better ways to validate it; Calvo's thesis names language models validated by human coding as the next step. I would build that measure for Swedish and Finnish, covering the target party and discrete emotions, and test that it works the same in the chamber and online. I would also supply real, measured posts as stimuli for the experiments led with Professor Renström. I am used to working independently to fixed deadlines alongside a demanding job, and to leading a cross-functional team and explaining technical results to non-technical colleagues.

Why third-cycle studies at Lund. Industry taught me to measure what people say online. It did not teach me to explain political behaviour, and that is the training I want. Your department combines democracy research and political psychology with growing computational work, from the Divided Parliaments project to research on machine learning and political text, and your projects with Professor Renström join elite communication to the psychology of voters. I would learn most in that environment, and I hope to contribute to it.

My references are Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, University of Portsmouth, my thesis supervisor and co-author (Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk), and Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, University of Portsmouth, who taught and assessed me (Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk). I can start on 1 January 2027 and would move to Lund. Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely,
Asad Ikram